

Modernist





Philippe Starck

1949 - Present





https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o1AvA00K2C8

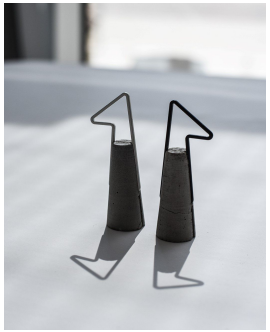
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z4PwHD7XKj0



ACTIVITY 1 - Starter: *Deconstructing Postmodernism*











"What does this object reveal about the beliefs of the designer?" and "How does the design reflect its purpose?"

Philippe Starck - 'democratic designer'

Philippe Starck's "democratic design" philosophy means creating high-quality, well-designed objects that are accessible and affordable to the widest possible audience, rather than exclusive to an elite group. He achieves this by focusing on mass-produced items, increasing production volume to reduce costs, and designing for functionality and longevity to improve people's daily lives.

Key Principles of Philippe Starck NOTES

Philippe Starck's key design principles include prioritizing accessibility and democracy in design, ensuring his work is useful, beautiful, and beneficial to the largest number of people. He emphasizes adding elements of joy, wonder, and humor to everyday life through his designs. Other core tenets are a deep commitment to humanity and the environment, the use of contrasting materials and shapes, and a philosophy of contributing to the world rather than just creating objects.

Democracy and Accessibility

- **Design for All:** Starck believes good design should not be exclusive and works to bring sophisticated and beautiful objects within reach of a broader audience, moving away from the idea of design as a symbol of wealth.
- **Usefulness:** A fundamental principle is that an object must be useful before it is beautiful.
- **Egalitarianism:** He seeks to share his humanistic vision for a more equitable planet through his unconventional projects, such as the redesign of the Paris transit pass, Pass Navigo.

Joy and Emotion

- **Adding Wonder:** Starck incorporates an element of wonder, joy, and excitement into everyday activities and spaces through his designs.
- **Storytelling:** He often uses his designs to tell stories, creating emotional experiences that allow people to discover what they are looking for, whether it is a place to have fun, get a drink, or simply feel good.

Key Principles on Philippe Starck... continued Notes

Humanity and Environment

- **Commitment to Humanity:** At the core of his philosophy is a profound commitment to humanity and the environment, aiming to create solutions for contemporary issues.
- **Sustainability:** He integrates eco-friendly practices, using recycled, renewable, and responsibly sourced materials, and focusing on energy efficiency in his designs to promote a more sustainable way of living.

Aesthetic and Materiality

- **Contrasting Elements:** Starck's designs often feature playful contrasts, such as traditional shapes with modern materials, or velvet with chrome.
- **Curvy and Fluid Shapes:** He often uses flowing, organic, and sometimes surprising shapes in his work, like the horn shape or teardrop.
- **Unusual Material Combinations:** He is known for pairing unexpected materials, like glass with stone or traditional elements with contemporary ones, to create unique and memorable designs.

ACTIVITY 2:





List design features that are influenced by modernism	Features that challenge or depart from modernist principles

ACTIVITY 2 - "Think-Pair-Share"

Task: "Which of Starck's products do you think best demonstrates an evolution of modernist thought, and why?"













Philippe Starck - Products







Activity 3: The Independent Judgement

In a single paragraph, **analyse and evaluate** the design of the **Philippe Starck Ghost Chair**. In your response, make a judgement on how its design is influenced by **both a key modernist design principle and a material innovation**.



Timed: 15 minutes

Activity 3: Exemplar Response

The Ghost Chair by Philippe Starck exemplifies an evolution of modernist design by adhering to the principle of democratic design, making high-quality products accessible through mass production. Its form, a ghost-like echo of a classical Louis XVI chair, is made possible by a single-shot polycarbonate injection mould, a technological innovation that allows for a complex, non-industrial aesthetic to be achieved through a highly industrial process. While its ornate form and historical reference seemingly depart from strict modernist principles, the chair's transparency and use of a single, honest material to achieve a functional and aesthetic goal demonstrates a continued focus on material innovation and a stripping away of unnecessary components. Ultimately, Starck's design makes a judgement that modernist ideals can be applied to create playful, culturally-resonant products without sacrificing functional honesty.

